

Achilles, sixty; Ajax the Less, forty; Ajax, son of Telamon, and Odysseus, twelve each.

11. Palamedes, son of Nauplius, was, after Odysseus, the cleverest of the Greeks; he was credited with a number of inventions. His unmasking of the "madness" earned him the hostility of Odysseus, who eventually contrived his death.
12. For the role of this secret in the story of Prometheus, p. 96; for Thetis' supplication to Zeus on behalf of Achilles, see p. 126.
13. Similar stories are those of Phaedra and Hippolytus, Bellerophon and Sthenoboea, and the biblical Joseph and Potiphar's wife (*Genesis* 39).
14. Similar magic was practiced by Demeter at Eleusis on the child Demophoön (see p. 338).
15. Nowhere does Homer mention a physical relationship between Achilles and Patroclus. In Plato's *Symposium*, Pausanias, probably not speaking in purely spiritual terms, identifies Patroclus as older and less beautiful than Achilles and his lover, contradicting Aeschylus, who (in a play no longer extant) made Achilles the lover rather than the beloved of Patroclus.
16. The figure is given in the *Catalogue* in Book 2 of the *Iliad*. Ancient as this document is and historically of the greatest importance, its numbers are inflated.
17. The most common version of his offense is that he had killed a stag sacred to the goddess. Some say that Artemis caused no winds to blow at all.
18. This version underlies Euripides' tragedy *Iphigenia in Tauris* (see p. 445).
19. After the Trojan War, Calchas challenged the seer Mopsus to a contest by asking him how many unripe figs there were on a nearby tree. When Mopsus gave the correct answer, Calchas died, for he was fated to do so if he met a more clever prophet than himself.
20. Some versions have Calchas make the prophecy and Neoptolemus accompany Odysseus to Lemnos. Aeschylus, Sophocles, and Euripides all wrote tragedies on Philoctetes; that of Sophocles is extant.
21. Pope's translation of this passage is given in Chapter 27 on the companion website.
22. Today Helen is often defended as the guiltless victim; for example, see Mihoko Suzuki, *Metamorphoses of Helen* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1989). Helen is studied in the depictions by Homer, Vergil, Spenser (*The Faerie Queene*), and Shakespeare (*Troilus and Cressida*), using theories of sacrifice and scapegoating and the conflict between patriarchal attitudes and victimized women.
23. Jonathan Shay, *Achilles in Vietnam* (New York: Atheneum, 1994).
24. Of great interest is *Penthesilea*, by the renowned German playwright Heinrich von Kleist, translated into English by Joel Agee, with pictures by Maurice Sendak (New York: HarperCollins, 1998).
25. This is the same Thersites who spoke out of turn in the assembly of the Greeks in Book 2 of the *Iliad*.
26. In another version, Thetis takes the corpse of Achilles to the island of Leuce (in the Black Sea), where she restores it to life. In Book 11 of the *Odyssey*, the ghost of Achilles talks with Odysseus and complains bitterly of his fate in the Underworld.
27. Ajax is the Latin form of the Greek Aias. For the metamorphosis of Hyacinthus, see p. 260.
28. Menelaüs narrates this episode in Book 4 of the *Odyssey* to Odysseus' son, Telemachus.
29. His sacrilege had a strange historical consequence; for a thousand years, the Locrians annually sent two daughters of noble families to serve as temple servants of Athena at Troy (i.e., the later foundations after the fall of Priam's city) as a penance for Ajax's crime. If any of these girls was caught by the Trojans before she reached the temple, she was put to death. This penance was ended not long before A.D. 100. There is a connection between the name Oïleus and the Greek name for Troy, Ilium.

30. The gods are here called by their Latin names.
31. Atalanta, daughter of Schoeneus, is easily confused with Atalanta of Arcadia. The latter also is a virgin huntress, who joined in the Calydonian boar hunt. She attempted to join the Argonauts' expedition, but Jason refused to accept her because he was concerned about a beautiful woman amidst a crew of all men. The most famous story about the Arcadian Atalanta revolves around her race with Milanion, who was also named Hippomenes (see p. 662).

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

The Returns and the *Odyssey*

I am a part of all that I have met.

—TENNYSON, *Ulysses*



Legends of the Returns

The returns of the Greek leaders from Troy were narrated in an epic called **Nostoi (Returns)**, of which only a brief prose summary and three lines of verse are extant.¹ It omits the return of Odysseus, which is the subject of Homer's *Odyssey*.

Agamemnon, Menelaüs, and Nestor

Agamemnon and Menelaüs quarreled over the departure and so parted company. Agamemnon sailed for Greece with part of the fleet, including the contingent of the Locrians. Near the island of Mykonos, Athena, angered by the sacrilege committed at Troy by the Locrian leader **Ajax** (p. 479), caused a storm to wreck many of the ships. Ajax swam to a nearby rock, where he boasted that not even the gods could prevent his escape from the dangers of the sea. For this blasphemy, Poseidon struck the rock with his trident, and Ajax was hurled into the sea and drowned.

During a second storm, which struck Agamemnon's fleet at Cape Caphareus in Euboea, Nauplius avenged the death of his son Palamedes

by luring many ships onto the rocks with a false beacon. Agamemnon finally reached Mycenae, only to be murdered by Aegisthus and Clytemnestra.

Meanwhile, Menelaüs, Nestor, and Diomedes set sail together from Troy. Nestor returned to Pylos safely. In the *Odyssey*, he tells Telemachus how Menelaüs lost all of his fleet except for five ships in a storm off Crete and eventually reached Egypt. On the advice of the sea-nymph **Eidothea**, Menelaüs forced her father, **Proteus**, to tell him how to appease the gods and secure a safe voyage home. Thus after seven years Menelaüs and Helen returned to Sparta, where they resumed their rule.² Euripides, perhaps to appeal to the anti-Spartan prejudices of Athenian audiences during the Peloponnesian War (432–404), makes Menelaüs a bombastic and ineffectual character in his tragedies *Andromache* (produced in 425) and *Orestes* (408). In the *Orestes*, Helen miraculously escapes being killed by Orestes and Electra, and Apollo announces that Helen has become a goddess, joining her brothers (Castor and Polydeuces) as protectors of seafarers (p. 446). At the end of his life, Menelaüs was transported to the Elysian Fields, avoiding the usual fate of going to Hades because he was the husband of Helen and the son-in-law of Zeus.

Diomedes

Diomedes reached Argos quickly, but there he found that his wife, Aegialia (daughter of Adrastus), had been unfaithful. Her adulteries were caused by Aphrodite, angry because Diomedes had wounded her at Troy. Diomedes left Argos and came to Italy, where the Apulian king, Daunus, gave him land. Diomedes founded several cities in Italy, but he declined to help King Latinus against Aeneas. After his death, Diomedes was worshiped as a hero in many places in Italy; in one story, Athena made him an immortal god.³ His followers were turned into birds.⁴

Idomeneus

Idomeneus returned to Crete to find that his wife, Meda, had committed adultery with Leucus, who had then murdered her and her daughter and made himself king over ten cities of Crete. Idomeneus was driven out by Leucus and came to Calabria in southern Italy, where he was worshiped as a hero after his death.⁵

Servius, the ancient commentator on Vergil, tells a legend that is similar to the biblical story of Jephthah's vow (*Judges* 11:30–11:40). Idomeneus was caught in a storm during the voyage home and vowed, if he were saved, to sacrifice to Poseidon the first living thing that met him. When he returned home, his son came out first to meet him. After Idomeneus had fulfilled his vow, a pestilence attacked the Cretans, who took it to be a divine punishment for Idomeneus' act and drove him into exile.

Philoctetes

Philoctetes returned to Thessaly but was driven out by his people. He came to southern Italy, where he founded a number of cities and after his death was worshiped as a hero.

The stories of Diomedes, Idomeneus, and Philoctetes seem to reflect the founding of Greek colonies in southern Italy from the eighth century onward. All three were worshiped as heroes after their death.

Neoptolemus

Achilles' son, Neoptolemus, warned by Thetis not to return by sea, took the land route back to Greece, accompanied by Helenus and Andromache. With them and his wife, **Hermione** (daughter of Menelaüs), he left his home in Phthia and came to Molossia in Epirus, where he ruled over the Molossi. He was killed at Delphi, and there became a hero with his own cult (see pp. 445–446).

The Return of Odysseus

The return of Odysseus forms a saga in itself, to which many folktale elements have accrued. Here is the summary of the *Odyssey* given by Aristotle in his *Poetics* (17.10):

The story of the *Odyssey* is not long; a man is away from home for many years; Poseidon constantly is on the watch to destroy him, and he is alone; at home his property is being wasted by suitors, and his son is the intended victim of a plot. He reaches home, tempest-tossed; he makes himself known, attacks his enemies and destroys them, and is himself saved. This is the heart of the matter: the rest is episodes.

The adventures of Odysseus have been taken as symbolic (e.g., Odysseus conquers death in his visit to the Underworld) or as connected with real places that had become known to the Greeks as their trade and colonization expanded. For the most part, however, they are romantic legends and folktales set in imaginary places and grafted onto the saga of a historical prince's return from a long absence.⁶

During the Trojan War, Odysseus was the wisest of the Greek heroes and a brave warrior. After Achilles' death, Odysseus inherited his divine armor. In the *Odyssey* he experiences many adventures, usually escaping from danger through his intelligence and courage. He meets with many men, women, goddesses, and monsters, and he remains faithful to **Penelope**, the wife whom he left in Ithaca with his son, **Telemachus**.⁷ Homer, with his customary perception and art, frames just the right introduction to establish our good faith in Odysseus. In Book 5, we first meet our hero, who has been marooned for seven years on the island of Ogygia, captive of the beautiful and divine nymph, Calypso. She comes down to the shore to find her unhappy victim Odysseus, pining for home (151–158):

Calypso found Odysseus sitting on the shore. His eyes were always wet with tears. His sweet life was ebbing away, while he bemoaned the impossibility of his homecoming, since the nymph no longer gave him any pleasure. The nights he was forced to spend lying with her in her grotto; certainly he did not want to, but she did. The days he spent amidst the rocks on the shore, his heart racked by tears and groans and misery, as he looked out across the barren sea, weeping.

Story of the *Odyssey*

At the time the poem begins, Odysseus is in the middle of his adventures. Books 1–4 relate the situation in Ithaca, where in Odysseus' absence Penelope is besieged by suitors who want her hand in marriage and with it her kingdom. As we have just seen, we first meet Odysseus in Book 5, detained on Ogygia, the island of the divine nymph Calypso. After he has sailed away from this island and his raft has been wrecked, Odysseus relates to his rescuers the events preceding his arrival on Ogygia. The poem then continues with the arrival of Odysseus on Ithaca, his revenge on the suitors for the hand of Penelope, and his eventual recognition by and reunion with Penelope.

The resourceful character of Odysseus dominates the story, but the gods also play a significant part, especially Poseidon, who is hostile to the hero, and Athena, who protects him. Homer introduces Odysseus in the opening lines (1. 1–21) of the *Odyssey*:

Of the man tell me, O Muse, the man of many ways,⁸ who traveled afar after he had sacked the holy city of Troy. He experienced the cities and the thoughts of many men, and his spirit suffered many sorrows on the sea, as he labored for



Calypso and Ulysses, by Emily Marshall; watercolor on paper, 1820–1835; 19 × 24 in. Calypso, in the dress of a woman of the early nineteenth century, tries to comfort Odysseus as he looks over the ocean and thinks of Penelope. Her left hand rests on his shoulder, and behind is a river landscape with a palm tree to give a suitably exotic air. Nothing is known of the artist, whose deceptively naïve style has caught the pathos of the situation in which the goddess and the hero find themselves. (Abby Aldrich Rockefeller Folk Art Museum, Colonial Williamsburg Foundation, Williamsburg, VA)

his own life and for the homecoming of his companions. Yet even so he could not protect his companions, much though he wished it, for they perished by their own folly, when thoughtlessly they had eaten the cattle of Helius, Hyperion the sun-god. And the god took away the day of their homecoming. From some point in these things, O goddess, daughter of Zeus, begin to tell me also the tale. (1. 1–10)

Then all the others, who had escaped sheer destruction, were at home, safe from the sea and the war. But this man alone, longing for his homecoming and his wife, did the nymph, the lady Calypso, keep in her hollow cave, desiring him as her husband. But when, as the years rolled round, that year came in which the gods had destined his return home to Ithaca, not even then did he escape from his labors nor was he with his friends. Yet the gods pitied him, all except Poseidon, and he unrelentingly was hostile to godlike Odysseus, until he returned to his own land. (1. 11–21)

10

The Cicones and the Lotus Eaters

It took Odysseus ten years to reach home. When he and his contingent left Troy, they came to the Thracian city of Ismarus, home of the Cicones, which they sacked before being driven off. They had spared **Maron**, priest of Apollo, in their attack, and he in return gave them twelve jars of fragrant red wine, which was to prove its value later. They were driven southward by a storm to the land of the lotus eaters. Here their reception was friendly but no less dangerous, for whoever ate of the fruit of the lotus forgot everything and wanted only to stay where he was, eating lotus fruit. Odysseus got his men away, even those who had tasted the fruit, and sailed to the land of the Cyclopes.

The Cyclopes

The Cyclopes were one-eyed giants, herdsmen, living each in his own cave. One of them was **Polyphemus**, son of Poseidon, whose cave Odysseus and twelve picked companions entered. In the cave were sheep and lambs, cheeses, and other provisions, to which they helped themselves while waiting for the return of the cave's owner. When Polyphemus returned with his flocks, he shut the entrance of the cave with a huge stone, and then caught sight of the visitors, two of whom he ate for his supper. He breakfasted on two more the next day and another two when he returned the second evening.

Now Odysseus had with him some of the wine of Maron, and with this he made Polyphemus drunk; he told him his name was **Nobody (Outis)**, and the giant, in return for the excellent wine, promised that he would reward Nobody by eating him last. He then fell asleep. Odysseus sharpened a wooden stake and heated it in the fire; then he and his surviving men drove it into the solitary eye of the sleeping giant. As he cried out in agony, the other Cyclopes came running to the cave's entrance, only to hear the cry "Nobody is killing me," so that they assumed that not much was wrong and left Polyphemus alone.

The next morning Polyphemus, now blind, removed the stone at the entrance and let his flocks out, feeling each animal as it passed. But Odysseus had tied his men each to the undersides of three sheep, and himself clung to the belly of the biggest ram; so he and his men escaped. As Odysseus sailed away,

he shouted his real name to the Cyclops, who hurled the top of a mountain at him and nearly wrecked the ship. Polyphemus had long before been warned of Odysseus, and as he recognized the name, he prayed to his father Poseidon (*Odyssey* 9. 530–536):

Grant that Odysseus may not return home, but if it is fated for him once more to see those he loves and reach his home and country, then let him arrive after many years, in distress, without his companions, upon another's ship, and may he find trouble in his house. . . . The prayer was heard.

The story of the one-eyed giant is one of the most frequently recurring folktales in the world. A particularly close parallel to Homer's version is found in the Voyages of Sinbad, related in *The Arabian Nights*.

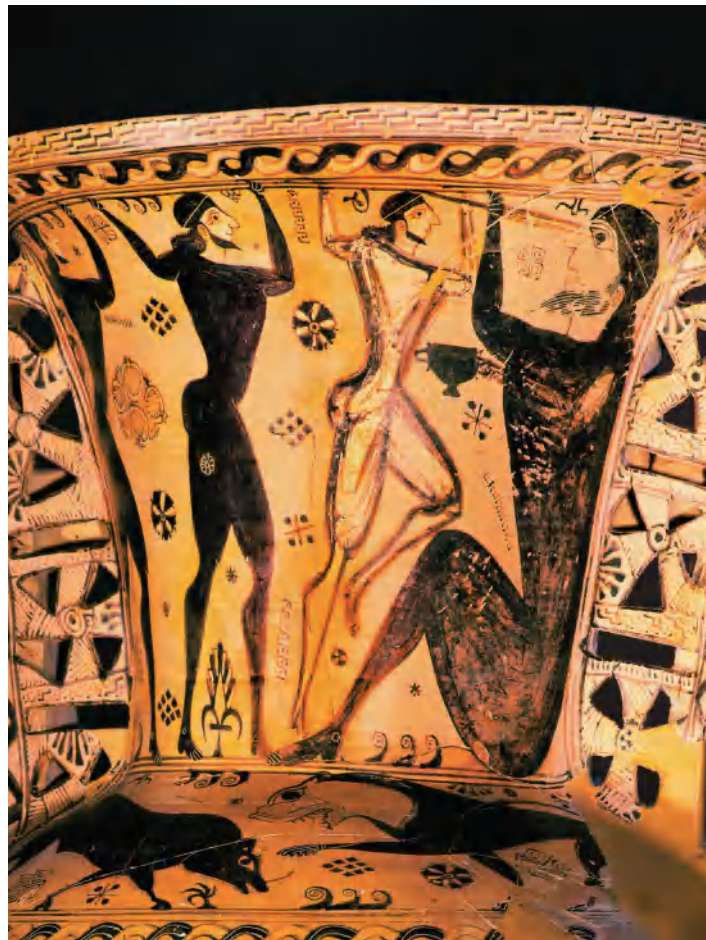
Aeolus and the Laestrygonians

Odysseus, reunited with the rest of his fleet, next reached the floating island of Aeolus, keeper of the winds, who lived with his six sons, who were married to his six daughters.⁹ After he had entertained Odysseus, Aeolus gave

him as a parting gift a leather bag containing all the winds and showed him which one to release so as to reach home. Thus he sailed back to Ithaca and was within reach of land when he fell asleep. His men, believing that the bag contained gold that Odysseus was keeping for himself, opened it, and all the winds rushed out and blew the ships back to Aeolus' island. Aeolus refused to help them any more, reasoning that the gods must hate them. Odysseus and his men sailed on to the land of the Laestrygonians who sank all Odysseus' ships except his own and ate up the crews. So Polyphemus' curse was already working, and Odysseus sailed away with his solitary ship.

Circe

Odysseus reached the island of **Aeaea**, the home of the witch Circe, daughter of the Sun. Odysseus divided his men into two groups; he stayed behind with the one, while the



The Blinding of Polyphemus. Proto-Attic vase from Eleusis, mid-seventh century B.C.; height of vase 56 in., of neck 15 in. Odysseus (painted in white) and his companions drive a long pole into the eye of the Cyclops, who holds the cup of wine that has made him drunk. This brutal scene is one of the earliest “free” vase paintings after the Geometric period. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)

other, twenty-three men in all, went to visit the ruler of the island. They found Circe with various animals around her, and they themselves (except for Eurylochus, who brought the news back to Odysseus) became pigs when they ate her food, swine in appearance and sound, but still having human minds.¹⁰ As Odysseus went to rescue his men, he encountered the god Hermes, who told him how to counter Circe's charms and gave him as an antidote the magic herb **moly**, whose "root is black and flower as white as milk." So he ate Circe's food unharmed and threatened her with his sword when she tried to turn him into a pig. She recognized him and instead made love to him. She then set a feast before him, which he would not touch before he had made her change his men back into their human shape. Odysseus lived with Circe for a year and by her begot a son, **Telegonus**. At the end of a year Odysseus, urged on by his men, asked Circe to send him on his way home. She agreed but told him that he first had to go to the Underworld where he would learn the way home from the prophet Tiresias.

The *Nekuia*

Book 11 of the *Odyssey*, which tells of Odysseus' experiences in the Underworld, is generally referred to as the Book of the Dead or the *Nekuia*, the name of the rite by which ghosts were summoned and questioned. Odysseus' visit to the Underworld is a conquest of death, the most formidable struggle a hero has to face. The hero who can return from the house of Hades alive has achieved all that a mortal can achieve. The *Nekuia* of Odysseus is different from its most famous imitation in one important respect: in the *Aeneid*, Aeneas actually descends to the Underworld and himself passes through it whereas Odysseus goes to the entrance and there performs the ritual sacrifice that summons up the spirits of the dead. Passages that tell of Odysseus' journey from Aeaea to the Underworld, his performance of the rite, and his conversations with a number of the ghosts are translated at length at the beginning of Chapter 15; here we provide a summary of his visit.

Odysseus Threatens Circe, Attic red-figure kalys krater by the Persephone painter, 440 B.C. In the upper panel, Circe has risen from her chair and runs away from Odysseus, dressed as a traveler and threatening her with his sword. She drops her wand and the bowl in which she had mixed her drugs. To the left, two of Odysseus' men approach with agitated gestures, one transformed into a boar and the other a donkey, but both still with human legs and arms. In the lower panel there is a pursuit with a young man and two women, but whether it illustrates a scene from myth is uncertain. (*The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York*, 41.83)



Following Circe's directions, Odysseus sailed with his men to the western limit of the world. As he performed the ritual sacrifice at the entrance to the world of the dead, many ghosts came, among them **Tiresias**, who foretold the disasters that yet awaited Odysseus on his journey. He would reach home, but alone and after many years. At Ithaca he would find the arrogant suitors pressing Penelope hard and wasting his substance. But he would kill them all, and he would have still more travels ahead of him before death came.

From Tiresias, Odysseus also learned that the spirits with whom he wished to speak must be allowed to drink the blood of the sacrificial victim; the others he kept away by threatening them with his sword. Among the ghosts who appeared and spoke were those of Odysseus' mother, **Anticlea**, and of Agamemnon, Achilles, and Ajax, son of Telamon. Achilles said that "he would rather be a slave to a poor man on earth than be king over all the souls of the dead." Ajax would not answer Odysseus a word, for he still was grieved by losing the contest for Achilles' arms.

Eventually, Odysseus left the house of Hades for fear that the Gorgon's head (which turns all whom it beholds to stone) might appear. He rejoined his men and sailed back to Aeaea.

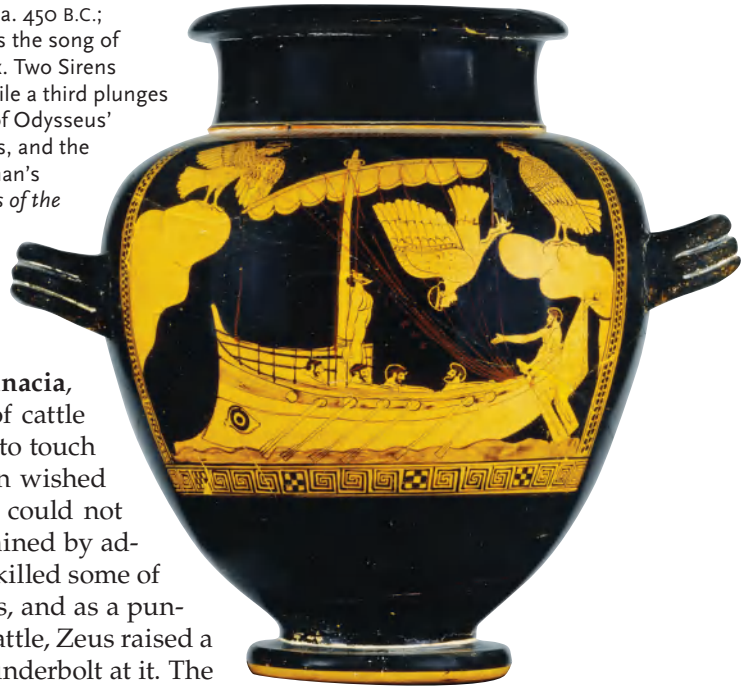
The Sirens, the Planctae, Charybdis, and Scylla

Circe sent Odysseus on his way after warning him of the dangers that lay ahead. First were the Sirens (said by Homer to be two in number, but by other authors to be more). To Homer they were human in form, but in popular tradition they were birdlike, with women's heads. From their island meadow they would lure passing sailors onto the rocks; all around them were the whitened bones of their victims. Odysseus sailed by them unharmed, stopping his men's ears with wax, while he had himself bound to the ship's mast so that he could not yield to the irresistible allurements of the Sirens' song, which tempted Odysseus, the cleverest of men, with the gift of further knowledge (*Odyssey* 12. 184–191):

"Come hither, famous Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans! Halt your ship so that you may hear our voice. For no one yet has sailed past this place in a black ship before hearing our sweet song. Then he sails on joyfully and endowed with greater knowledge. For we know all that the Argives and the Trojans endured in the broad plain of Troy through the will of the gods. And we know everything that happens upon the fertile earth."

The next danger was the two wandering rocks (Planctae) between which one ship only, the *Argo*, had ever safely passed. Odysseus avoided them by sailing close to two high cliffs; in the lower of these lived Charybdis (she is not described by Homer), who three times a day sucked in the water of the strait and spouted it upward again. To sail near that cliff was certain destruction, and Odysseus chose as the lesser evil the higher cliff where was the cave of Scylla, daughter of the sea deity Phorcys. Originally a sea-nymph, she had been changed through the jealousy of Poseidon's wife Amphitrite into a monster with a girdle of six dogs' heads and with twelve feet, by means of which she would snatch sailors from passing ships. From Odysseus' ship she snatched six men, whom she ate in her cave. Odysseus and the rest of the crew were unharmed.

Odysseus and the Sirens. Athenian red-figure stamnos, ca. 450 B.C.; height 13 $\frac{3}{4}$ in. Odysseus, lashed to the mast, safely hears the song of the Sirens as his men row by, their ears plugged with wax. Two Sirens (winged creatures with human heads) stand on cliffs, while a third plunges headlong into the sea. The artist, by the dramatic angle of Odysseus' head, expresses the hero's longing to be free of his bonds, and the turned head of the oarsman on the right and the helmsman's gesture add further tension to the scene. (© *The Trustees of the British Museum*)



The Cattle of the Sun

Last, Circe told Odysseus of the island of **Thrinacia**, where Helius (the Sun) pastured his herds of cattle and sheep; she strictly warned Odysseus not to touch a single one of the animals if he and his men wished ever to return to Ithaca. But Odysseus' men could not show such restraint after weeks of being detained by adverse winds, and while he was sleeping they killed some of the cattle for food. Helius complained to Zeus, and as a punishment for the sacrilege of killing the god's cattle, Zeus raised a storm when the ship set sail and hurled a thunderbolt at it. The ship sank, and all the men were drowned except for Odysseus, who escaped, floating on the mast and part of the keel.

After the wreck, Odysseus drifted back to Charybdis, where he avoided death by clinging to a tree growing on the cliff until the whirlpool propelled his mast to the surface after sucking it down.

Calypso

Odysseus drifted over the sea to **Ogygia**, the island home of Calypso, daughter of Atlas, with whom he lived for seven years. Although she loved him and offered to make him immortal, he could not forget Penelope. Finally, after Hermes brought her Zeus' express orders, Calypso helped Odysseus build a raft and sail away.

The Phaeacians

Even now Odysseus was not free from disaster; Poseidon saw him as he approached **Scheria** (the island of the Phaeacians) and shattered the raft with a storm. After two days and two nights, helped by the sea-goddess **Leucothea** (formerly the mortal Ino, daughter of Cadmus) and by Athena, he reached land, naked, exhausted, and alone.

The king of the Phaeacians was **Alcinoüs**, and his daughter was **Nausicaä**. The day after Odysseus landed, Nausicaä went to wash clothes near the seashore and came face to face with Odysseus. She gave him her protection and brought him back to the palace. Here he was warmly entertained by Alcinoüs and his queen, **Arete**, and related the story of his adventures to them. The Phaeacians gave him rich gifts, and a day later they brought him back to Ithaca on one of their ships, in a deep sleep. So Odysseus reached Ithaca ten years after the fall of



The Return of Odysseus. It is difficult to overlay a legendary landscape upon a real geography, and the map indicates the uncertainty of precise identification. Most of the places Odysseus visits are impossible to locate, though the attempt has not stopped ingenious speculation. Even in antiquity, many believed that the western Mediterranean was the focus of Odysseus' wandering, whereas the most famous of the adventures of Jason, which may in fact be older than those of Odysseus' voyage, take place in and around the Black Sea region. The first chapters of the *Geography of Strabo*, a first century A.D. geographer, are particularly illuminating on the subject of Homeric geography and the ideas current in Strabo's time.

To explore an interactive version of this map, please go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

Odysseus and Nausicaä. Red-figure amphora, ca. 440 B.C. On the left, Odysseus holds two olive branches (signaling that he is a suppliant), while Athena, her head turned toward him, stands between him and Nausicaä (seen on the right). Encouraged by Athena, Nausicaä stops running away and turns toward Odysseus. Behind Odysseus, clothes hang on a tree to dry. (*Amphora, red-figure pottery, Detail showing Ulysses, Athena and Nausicaa, Greek Civilization, 6th–4th Century BC/De Agostini Picture Library/The Bridgeman Art Library*)

Troy, alone and on another's ship, as Polyphemus had prayed. Yet even now Poseidon did not relax his hostility. As the Phaeacians' ship was entering the harbor of Scheria on its return, Poseidon turned the ship and its crew to stone as a punishment of the Phaeacians for conveying strangers over the seas, especially those who were the objects of Poseidon's hatred.

Ithaca

In Ithaca, more than one hundred suitors (young noblemen from Ithaca and the nearby islands) were courting Penelope in the hope of taking Odysseus' place as her husband and as king of Ithaca (for Telemachus, Odysseus' son by Penelope, was considered still too young to succeed). They spent their days feasting at Odysseus' palace, wasting his possessions. Penelope, however, remained faithful to Odysseus, even though he seemed to be dead. She put the suitors off by promising to choose one of them when she finished weaving a magnificent cloak intended as a burial garment for Odysseus' father, Laertes. For three years she wove the robe by day and undid her work by night, but in the fourth year her deception was uncovered, and a decision was now unavoidable.

At this stage Odysseus returned. Helped by Athena, he gained entrance at the palace disguised as a beggar, after finding refuge in the hut of his faithful old swineherd, **Eumaeus**, and revealing his identity to his son, Telemachus. Telemachus had been on a journey to Pylos and Sparta and had learned from Nestor and Menelaüs that his father was still alive. Outside the palace, Odysseus' old hound, **Argus**, recognized his master after nineteen years' absence and died.

At the palace, Odysseus was insulted by the suitors and by another beggar, Irus, whom he knocked out in a fight. Still in disguise, he gave Penelope an exact description of Odysseus and of a curious brooch he had worn. As a result, she confided in him her plan to give herself next day to the suitor who succeeded in stringing Odysseus' great bow and shooting an arrow straight through a row of twelve axe heads. Also at this time, Odysseus was recognized by his old nurse, **Euryclea**, who knew him from a scar on his thigh, which he had received when hunting a boar with his grandfather, Autolycus. Thus the scene was set for Odysseus' triumphant return; his son and his faithful



retainers knew the truth, and Penelope had fresh encouragement to prepare her for the eventual recognition.

The Bow and the Killing of the Suitors

The trial of the bow took place the next day. When none of the suitors could even so much as string it, Odysseus asked to be allowed to try. Effortlessly, he achieved the task and shot the arrow through the axes. Next he shot the leading suitor, **Antinoös**, and in the ensuing fight he and Telemachus and their two faithful servants killed all the other suitors. The scene where Odysseus strings the bow and reveals himself to the suitors is one of the most dramatic in all epic poetry (*Odyssey* 21. 404–423; 22. 1–8):



Audio

But crafty Odysseus straightway took the great bow in his hands and looked at it on all sides, just as a man who is skilled at the lyre and at song easily stretches a string round a new peg, fitting the well-turned sheep's gut around the peg—even so without effort did he string the great bow, did Odysseus. He took it in his right hand and made trial of the string, and it sang sweetly under his hand, in sound like a swallow. Then great sorrow seized the suitors, and in all of them their skin changed color. Zeus, giving a sign, thundered loudly. Then godlike, patient Odysseus rejoiced that the son of wily Cronus had sent him a sign. Then he chose a swift arrow, one that lay on the table beside him uncovered, while the others lay in the hollow quiver—and these the Achaeans would soon feel. This arrow, then, he took, and he drew back the string and the notched arrow, sitting where he was on his stool. And he shot the arrow aiming straight ahead, and of the hafted axes he missed none from the first to the last, and the arrow weighted with bronze sped straight through to the end. . . . (21. 404–423)

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Then wily Odysseus stripped off his rags, and he leaped to the great threshold holding the bow and the quiver full of arrows, and he poured out the arrows in front of his feet. Then he spoke to the suitors: "This my labor inexorable has been completed. Now I shall aim at another target which no man has yet struck, if I can hit it and Apollo grants my prayer." He spoke and shot a death-dealing arrow straight at Antinoös. (22. 1–8)

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All the suitors were killed; only the herald, Medon, and the bard, Phemius, were spared. Odysseus called Euryclea to identify the twelve servant-women who had insulted him and had been the lovers of the suitors. They were forced to cleanse the hall, and then they were mercilessly hanged, while the disloyal goatherd, Melanthius, was mutilated and killed. The consequences of the battle in the hall were grisly, a reminder that Odysseus was a warrior who had taken part in the sack of Troy and was merciless to his enemies.

The Father of Odysseus

Laertes is usually identified as the father of Odysseus, and in the last book of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus after his return to Ithaca reveals his identity to his father, Laertes, in a moving scene.

One story, however, makes **Sisyphus**, the son of Aeolus, the father of Odysseus, whose mother, Anticlea, he seduced before she married Laertes.

Anticlea's father was the master thief **Autolycus**, son of Hermes, who gave him the power to steal whatever he wished undetected. For a long time he was in the habit of stealing Sisyphus' cattle until Sisyphus branded the animals on their hooves and so easily recognized and recovered those that Autolycus had stolen. The two heroes became friends, and Autolycus allowed Sisyphus to lie with Anticlea. Thus (in this version) the trickster Sisyphus, a sinner in Hades (see p. 359), was really the father of Odysseus, who inherited his devious nature.

Telemachus

The *Odyssey's* portrait of Telemachus, the son of Odysseus and Penelope, is a masterful depiction of the hero as a young man. His introduction in Book 1 establishes his character with sure and subtle brevity. Athena has come down from Olympus to inspire courage and action in Telemachus, still a boy at heart. We first meet him in the palace, helplessly witnessing the abusive arrogance of the suitors. He sits sad and despondent, daydreaming that his father had already returned and driven out the suitors and saved him from their insolence and disrespect. Amidst their drunken revels, he is the only one to notice Athena disguised as Mentès waiting at the threshold. He alone rises and greets her with the courtesy demanded by the sacred bond of guest-friendship. In a few lines, we know that Telemachus is a worthy son of his heroic father, and we are prepared for his gratifying development. By the end of Book 1, he will have stood up to his mother, who is surprised by his manly effort to break loose from her. He will go on to have an odyssey of his own (appropriately a mini-odyssey, to be sure, in Books 3 and 4) to Pylos and Sparta to obtain news of Odysseus from Nestor and Menelaüs and Helen. When Odysseus does return, it is Telemachus who can almost, but not quite yet, string his father's bow, although he would have done so if his father had allowed him a fourth try. At the climax of the poem, it is father and son, side by side, who kill the suitors.

Penelope

We have said earlier that Odysseus "remained faithful to Penelope," and the reunion with his wife is the goal of the epic. Penelope is not a passive figure: she is the equal of Odysseus in intelligence and loyalty, and she is resourceful in fending off the suitors and, equally significant, in choosing her time and method for recognition of Odysseus. When she finally does recognize him, the poet describes her "as fitting his heart" (*thymares*); that is, she is a perfect match for the man who is the "man of many twists and turns" (*polytropos*, an epithet given him in the first line of the poem), the cleverest of the Greeks.

Penelope's usual epithet is *periphron* (circumspect); that is, she is wary and resourceful, able to keep the suitors at bay by her intelligence. In her first meeting with Odysseus (in Book 19), she says: "I spin out my stratagems," and she tells him of the weaving and unraveling of the burial garment for Laertes. She used her sexual power to weaken the suitors. When she appears before them, she is repeatedly likened to Aphrodite and Artemis, and "the suitors' knees went slack; she bewitched their spirits with lust, and all longed to lie beside her in bed"

Two Returns of Odysseus

Bernardino di Betto, nicknamed Pinturicchio (Little Painter) because of his small stature, was born in Perugia around 1454 and died in Siena in 1513. Though details of his early life are scant, it is known that he worked with Perugino on frescoes for the Sistine Chapel. Pinturicchio achieved fame for many of his frescoes, including those decorating the Vatican apartments commissioned by Pope Alexander VI and those decorating the Piccolomini Library in the cathedral of Siena. The National Gallery in London houses Pinturicchio's famous fresco, later transferred to canvas, entitled *Penelope and the Suitors*, commissioned by Pandolfo Petrucci. Pinturicchio's fresco was painted to celebrate Petrucci's wedding in 1509. In 1512, Petrucci became ruler of Siena.

During this period, Italy was made up of small principalities and states that were continually vying for dominance over one another. Siena itself witnessed bloody conflict between various factions within the city. The story of Odysseus' return, his killing of the suitors, and his reunion with his wife were intended to underscore the calculation and brutality necessary to keep and maintain power in the state. Even so, there is some debate regarding who the central figure in the fresco is meant to be. As stated in the caption, it may indeed be Telemachus, bursting into the room to tell his mother Penelope that his father has returned and the suitors are dead. But if so, Pinturicchio is taking liberties with the narrative. In the *Odyssey*, the nurse Euryclea rushes upstairs to rouse Penelope from her slumber and tell her that her husband is home and the suitors are killed. Penelope rather poignantly says that she has not slept so well since the day Odysseus sailed away, but at first she does not believe the nurse's news. Penelope goes downstairs to find out for herself what has happened and discovers Odysseus sitting against a great



Closer Look

The Return of Odysseus, by Pinturicchio (Bernardo Betti, 1454–1513); fresco transferred to canvas, 1509, 60 × 50 in. To the left sits Penelope at her loom, with Euryclea beside her; above her head are the bow and quiver of Odysseus. Telemachus runs to greet his mother, and behind him are a young suitor (note the falcon on his wrist), the seer Theoclymenus, and Eumaeus. Odysseus, disguised as a beggar, is coming through the door on the right. In the background is the ship of the Phaeacians; to its left is Odysseus' boat being shattered by Poseidon, and, in the wooded landscape beyond, Odysseus meets Circe, while his men root around as pigs. This fresco was originally painted for a wall in a room of the Ducal Palace in Siena. (© National Gallery, London/ Art Resource, NY)



column staring at the ground, waiting for her to speak. Penelope is wary. Telemachus is also present and begins to chastise her for her stubbornness, but Odysseus sends him out on an errand so that she can question her husband. Another interpretation is that the central figure is simply one of the suitors. The scene may represent Penelope's trick of the loom at the moment it is exposed.

Romare Bearden (1911–1988) is one of the most acclaimed artists of the twentieth century. He was born in Charlotte, North Carolina, but eventually settled in New York. The Harlem Renaissance, an efflorescence of African American culture in the 1920s, had an important influence on him in his youth. Throughout his career, Bearden worked in a variety of media and had many cultural influences. He is perhaps best known for his collages. He found inspiration in some of the greatest artists of the European tradition, including Giotto, Picasso, and of course, Pinturicchio. Collage became a way for Bearden to express his sensitivity to collaborative work and to art that reflected the harmonious unity one can achieve through the creative joining of discrete elements. The collage, in form and content, was a method for integrating his art with his concerns for racial equality; the medium also reflected the African American experience in its angularity, broken pieces, fractured perspective, and sharp juxtapositions.

In 1977, Bearden produced a series of collages entitled *Black Odyssey*, based on episodes from Homer's *Odyssey*. In his collage *The Return of Odysseus* (*Homage to Pinturicchio and Benin*), Bearden deliberately juxtaposes this contemporary art form with the classical story, relating the myth of Odysseus, his suffering, and his ultimate triumph directly to the African American experience. He also celebrates the influence of European and African traditions. The European influence is evident in his debt to Pinturicchio's fresco, and the African influence is seen in his use of black figures reminiscent of the sculpture of the African kingdom of Benin from the fourteenth through the seventeenth centuries.



Closer Look

The Return of Odysseus.

Watercolor, gouache, and ink on paper (1977) by Romare Bearden (1912–1988): 12 ¾ × 15 ½ in. Bearden twice expressed his “Homage to Pinturicchio,” first in a collage of 1969 with this title. Bearden’s mythological figures are black, for, as he remarked, “if a child in Benin or in Louisiana . . . sees my paintings of Odysseus, he can understand the myth better.” The figures are the same as in Pinturicchio’s painting, with a simpler version of the Phaeacians’ ship in the background and Odysseus, in green and yellow, hardly visible as he enters in the top right corner. (Art © Romare Bearden Foundation/Licensed by VAGA, New York, NY)

(*Odyssey* 18. 212–214). She gets them to give her gifts (observed with joy by Odysseus himself, who is in the hall disguised as a beggar), and, when it appears inevitable that she must choose one of them, she devises the test of the bow. Finally, she insists that the stranger (i.e., Odysseus, with whom, as we have seen earlier, she had conversed) be allowed to take part in the test. But before Odysseus actually strings the bow, she is told by Telemachus (now for the first time asserting himself as his father's heir apparent and head of the household) to go upstairs. Thus she is absent during Odysseus' successful stringing of the bow, the battle in the hall and its cleansing, and the killing of the servants. The stage is set, as it were, for the climactic scene between Penelope and Odysseus, leading to recognition and reunion.

At their first meeting (in Book 19), she had asked the stranger who he was, and he had begun his reply by likening her to a king who rules over a just and prosperous city—in other words, he likens his wife to himself as king of Ithaca. Later (still not revealing how much she knows of his identity), she shares with him a dream in which an eagle kills her flock of twenty geese, and he agrees with her that it is an omen of Odysseus' return. Penelope's words are fraught with psychological import. She begins with confidences about how her nights are filled with anxiety. She lies awake, miserable with indecision (525–534):

Should I stay here by the side of my son and keep all my possessions safe, my property, my slaves, and my grand and lofty palace, respecting the bed of my husband and what people might say, or should I go off with the best one of the Achaeans here who court me and offer lavish gifts? As for my son, as long as he was still young and immature, he would not allow me to leave the palace and marry a new husband, but now that he is grown up and has reached maturity, he beseeches me to go away, so upset is he about his estate, which these Achaeans are swallowing up.

Penelope goes on to relate her dream (535–553):

Now I want you to listen to a dream of mine and interpret it for me. At my home there are twenty geese who come to eat corn from a water-trough, and I love watching them. But down from a mountain swoops a huge eagle with hooked beak, and he breaks their necks and kills them all. They lie strewn together about the house, but he flies aloft into the divine upper air. I weep and wail, although it is only a dream and the Achaean women with lovely hair gather round me as I grieve bitterly because the eagle has killed my geese. He comes back and perched on a beam jutting from the roof speaks in a human voice and restrains my tears. "Take heart, daughter of renowned Icarius. This is not a dream but a reality, a good deed that will be accomplished. The geese are your suitors and I who am the eagle in your dream will come back as your husband, who will bring a sorry fate down upon all your suitors." Thus he spoke and honeyed sleep left me. Looking around, I saw my geese in the courtyard by the trough, pecking at the grain, exactly where they were before.

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The stranger in a brief answer assures Penelope that there is only one possible interpretation of her dream. Certain death lies in store for each and every suitor. We wonder how Odysseus feels about Penelope's avowed affection for her



The Washing of Odysseus' Feet. Attic red-figure skyphos, ca. 440 B.C.; height 8 in., diameter 6.2 in. Euryclea (named Antiphata on the vase) looks up at Odysseus with her mouth open, as she recognizes him from the scar. To the right is the hand of Eumaeus, evidently offering a gift to Odysseus, who wears the traveler's cap and carries the beggar's basket and stick. On the other side, Penelope sits sadly at her loom, while Telemachus talks with her. (*Soprintendenza per i Beni Archeologici della Toscana—Firenze*)

geese and marvel at Homer's subtle portrait of a complex woman, devoted to her husband but wary about her own future and not unflattered and unmoved by the attention and the gifts of a flock of suitors. Could she knowingly be leading this stranger on?

After the battle in the hall, Penelope is wakened by Euryclea and refuses to admit that the stranger is Odysseus (we are not told whether she thinks he is). She comes down, and she and Odysseus sit opposite each other. When Telemachus reproves her for not embracing Odysseus she replies that if the stranger truly is Odysseus then "we will know it from each other even better, for we have signs which we know, hidden from others." Then she orders Euryclea to move the bed, which Odysseus himself had made, out of the marriage-chamber for him to sleep on outside.

Odysseus is furious that anyone would move his bed, for he had built it using a living olive tree as one of its supports and building the marriage-chamber around it. Thus he revealed the secret, and Penelope knew now that it was he.¹¹ Then, and only then, did she give way and embrace the husband who had been away for twenty years. The poet again uses a simile for Penelope that identifies her with Odysseus (*Odyssey* 23. 232–240):

He wept as he held the wife who matched his heart (*thymares*). Just as land is a welcome sight to shipwrecked sailors whose well-made ship Poseidon has

shattered on the sea, battering it with wind and wave: few escape from the grey sea to reach land, and their skin is caked with brine, but they escape destruction and stand on land with joy—even so with joy did she look upon her husband, and her white arms would not let go of his neck.

In a sense, Penelope is Odysseus, the sailor wrecked by Poseidon who reaches land. Thus by the similes of the king and the sailor, and by her resourceful patience and deliberate testing of the stranger, she gets him to reveal himself and proves herself to be his match.

The poet describes the end of Odysseus' labors with tact and delicacy. At the same time, he allows Odysseus to recall his adventures (*Odyssey* 23. 300–343):

So when they (Odysseus and Penelope) had taken their delight in the joys of love, they took delight in words and spoke to each other. She, goddess-like among women, told of all she had endured in the hall as she watched the



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Naming Odysseus

After Euryclea has recognized Odysseus from the scar on his thigh, Homer tells the story of the naming of Odysseus. His grandfather, Autolycus (father of Anticlea, the mother of Odysseus), was asked to name the infant, whom Euryclea had placed on his knees. "I shall call him *Odysseus*," he said, "because I have come being hateful [Greek, *odyssamenos*] to many men and women all over the fruitful earth." The Greek word is in the middle voice; that is, its subject can be either "an agent of rage or hatred but also its sufferer" (B. Knox's phrase). George Dimock suggests "man of pain," implying both the hero's sufferings and the suffering that he caused to others.

The anonymity or naming of Odysseus is an essential element in his story. In the first line of the *Odyssey*, he is simply "[the] man": contrast the first line of the *Iliad*, where the hero, Achilles, is named. The conventions of heroic hospitality allowed hosts to ask their guest's name after he had eaten at their table: so Antinoüs asks, "Tell me the name that your mother and father call you by [at home]," and only then does Odysseus reply (*Odyssey* 9. 19), "I am Odysseus, son of Laertes." Odysseus controls the revelation of his name: for example, urged on by Athena, he chooses when to reveal himself to Telemachus in Book 16. Euryclea's discovery caught him by surprise, and his reaction was to threaten to kill her if she revealed it to others. The Cyclops asks his name and is told that it is *Outis* ("Nobody"). Arrived on Ithaca, Odysseus tells Athena that he is a Cretan. Penelope's first question at their first interview (19. 105) is, "Tell me, what people do you come from? Where are your city and your parents?" and Odysseus replies that he is a Cretan named *Aethon* [shining, an epithet like that of the Cretan queen, *Phaedra*, bright]. Only after outwitting him with the test of the bed does Penelope finally achieve the self-revelation of the hero. Odysseus, "man of pain," is indeed both "Nobody" and the universal hero.¹²

[Note: The Latin name for Odysseus is *Ulixes* or *Ulysses*, etymologically the same as the Greek name, with *Od-* shifting to *Ul-*, possibly (it has been suggested) influenced by a local dialect in Sicily or southern Italy.]

unseemly mob of suitors, who to win her slaughtered many oxen and fine sheep and drank many casks of wine. In his turn godlike Odysseus told all, the cares he had brought upon men and the grievous sufferings that he had endured. She delighted in his tale, and sleep did not fall upon her eyes until he had finished his tale. (23. 300–309)

He told first how he had subdued the Cicones and how he had come to the fertile land of the lotus-eating men. He told of the Cyclops' deeds and how he avenged his valiant companions, whom the Cyclops had pitilessly devoured. He told how he came to Aeolus, who received him kindly and sent him onward, yet it was not yet destined for him to come to his own dear land, for a storm again snatched him and bore him over the fish-full sea, groaning deeply. He told how he came to Telepylus and the Laestrygonians, who destroyed his ships and his well-greaved companions. He told of the deceit and wiles of Circe, and he told how he came to the dank house of Hades to consult the soul of Theban Tiresias, sailing on his well-benched ship. There he saw his companions and his mother, who bore him and nourished him when he was a baby. (23. 310–325)

He told how he heard the song of the clear-voiced Sirens and how he came to the wandering rocks of the Planctae, and to terrible Charybdis and Scylla, whom no man before had escaped alive. He told how his companions had slain the cattle of Helius, and how Zeus, who thunders in the high heavens, had struck his swift ship with a smoky thunderbolt and killed all his companions, and only he escaped evil death. He told how he came to the island Ogygia and the nymph Calypso, who kept him there in her hollow cave, desiring him to be her husband. She fed him and promised to make him immortal and ageless all his days, yet she did not persuade the heart in his breast. He told how, after many sufferings, he reached the Phaeacians, who honored him like a god and sent him with a ship to his own dear homeland with ample gifts of bronze and gold and clothing. (23. 326–340)

This was the last tale he told, when sweet sleep came upon him, sleep that relaxes the limbs and releases the cares of the spirit.

The End of the *Odyssey*

The last book of the *Odyssey* begins with Hermes escorting the souls of the dead suitors to the House of Hades, where they converse with the souls of Agamemnon and Achilles. The ghost of Amphimedon (one of the leading suitors) tells Agamemnon's ghost of Penelope's weaving and the test of the bow and the slaughter of the suitors. Agamemnon's ghost replies (*Odyssey* 24. 192–200):

Happy son of Laertes, wily Odysseus! You married a wife of great excellence (*arete*)! How virtuous was the mind of peerless Penelope, daughter of Icarius! How well she kept the memory of Odysseus, her wedded husband! Therefore the fame of her virtue will never fade, and the immortals will fashion a lovely song for mortals to sing in honor of Penelope, the wife who kept her counsel. She did not contrive crimes like the daughter of Tyndareus, who murdered her wedded husband.

Penelope is repeatedly contrasted with Clytemnestra in the *Odyssey*, most eloquently by Agamemnon himself.¹³ Meanwhile, Odysseus leaves the palace to find his father, Laertes, who is living as a farmer, away from the city. At first he conceals his identity from the old man, but soon he reveals himself. As they are sharing a meal in Laertes' farmhouse, news comes that the relatives of the suitors are approaching to avenge their deaths. Once again Odysseus must fight, helped by Athena, and Laertes, miraculously energized by the goddess, kills Eupheithes, father of Antinoös. At this point Athena orders the men to stop fighting, and Zeus casts a thunderbolt at her feet to confirm her command. She makes peace between Odysseus and the suitors' families, and so the epic ends.

Odysseus and Athena

Odysseus was especially helped by the goddess Athena, whose own attributes of wisdom and courage complement his gifts. The relationship of goddess and hero is brilliantly depicted by the poet in a scene after Odysseus, asleep, has been put ashore on Ithaca by the Phaeacians and wakes up, not knowing where he is. Athena, disguised as a young shepherd, has told him that he is on Ithaca (*Odyssey* 13. 250–255, 287–301):

Thus she spoke, and patient godlike Odysseus was glad, rejoicing in his own fatherland, as Pallas Athena had told him, the daughter of Zeus, bearer of the aegis. And he replied to her with winged words. He did not tell her the truth, but he held it back, always directing his mind in his breast for every advantage. [Odysseus then makes up a story which, however, does not fool the goddess.] (250–255)

Thus he spoke, and the goddess, grey-eyed Athena, smiled and stroked him with her hand. In form she was like to a beautiful and tall woman, one who is expert in fine handiwork. She addressed him with these winged words: (287–290)

“Crafty and wily would he be who could surpass you in every trick, even if a god were to compete with you. You rogue, deviser of tricks, never satisfied with deceit, even in your own land you were not going to abandon your deceit and your deceiving words, which are dear to you from your inmost heart. Still, come now, let us no longer talk like this, since we both know how to get the advantage. For you are by far the best of all mortals in counsel and in words, and I am famous among all the gods for wisdom and cunning. Yet you did not recognize Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus, who stands beside you in every labor and protects you.” (291–301)

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The End of Odysseus' Life

Homer tells the subsequent history of Odysseus in the words of Tiresias' prophecy (*Odyssey* 11. 119–137):

When you have killed the suitors in your palace . . . then you must go, carrying a well-made oar, until you come to men who know not the sea nor eat food

flavored with salt; nor know they of red-painted ships nor of shapely oars, which are the wings of ships. This shall be a clear sign that you shall not miss: when another traveler meets you and says that you have a winnowing-fan upon your fine shoulder, then plant the well-turned oar in the ground and sacrifice to Poseidon . . . and to all the immortal gods. And death shall come to you easily, from the sea, such as will end your life when you are weary after a comfortable old age, and around you shall be a prosperous people.

Odysseus appeased Poseidon in the manner foretold by Tiresias, founding a shrine to Poseidon where he planted the oar. He returned to Ithaca. Years later, Telegonus, who had grown up on his mother Circe's island, sailed to Ithaca in search of his father. He was plundering the island and killed Odysseus, who was defending his possessions, not knowing who he was.¹⁴

The Universality of the *Odyssey*

The *Odyssey* is a splendid intermingling of true myth (tales about the gods), legend (stories ultimately reflecting the history of real heroes and heroines), and folktales, fairytales, and the like, which both amuse and edify. It is, perhaps, the finest example of the persistent mythological theme of the legendary Quest. In the case of Odysseus, his personal quest brings him back home, surmounting all obstacles on his journey to punish the wicked and regain his wife, his son, and his kingdom. In subsequent literature, he has become a kind of Everyman. Certainly, to the Romans Odysseus (Ulysses) was a symbol of virtuous patience, and his endurance of adversity made him an example, especially for the Stoics. Plato, in the myth of Er that ends the *Republic*, shows Odysseus in the Underworld choosing for his next life an inconspicuous existence because of his memory of adversity (see p. 365).

Odysseus, then, perhaps more than any other, is the archetypal hero, just as Penelope is par excellence the archetypal heroine, each beautifully illustrating aspects of an exemplary human and heroic *arete* (excellence). Recently, special attention has been given to the character and motives of Penelope. She has been seen as the peer of Odysseus in intelligence and in patience, qualities shown in her resistance to the long siege by the suitors and in her restraint on declaring her recognition of Odysseus. Penelope's reluctance to recognize Odysseus has increasingly been interpreted as a manifestation of her wisdom and self-control, leading attributes of her husband. The final reunion of husband and wife is consummated through the incident concerning their shared knowledge about the solid construction of their immovable marriage bed, with the olive tree forming one leg, a powerful symbol of the strength and persistence of their physical and spiritual love.

Homer's great epic has a unique, universal appeal to both young and old—and to the child and philosopher in us all. It can be read solely as a most entertaining story of travel and adventure, full of exciting episodes of delightful variety, a tale of abiding love that ends happily, with the just triumph of good over evil, or it can reveal to the artist and the sage the most profound insights about men and women, the gods and fate, and the meaning of human existence. The word "odyssey" itself has come into our language as synonymous with a journey and a quest, and never has the word "homecoming" found a more joyous resonance or deeper meaning than in the final books of the poem.¹⁵

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Homer	<i>Odyssey</i> (selections)

Additional Sources

Apollodorus	<i>Library</i> , Epitome 1–6.29 (the returns of the heroes); 7.1–7.40 (the return of Odysseus)
Epic Cycle	<i>Nostoi</i> (Returns)
Euripides	<i>Cyclops</i>